Getting Sex Out of the Schools and Back into the Gutter Where It Belongs

By Erma Bombeck

INTRODUCTION

The fact that the morality of this nation has greatly deteriorated cannot be successfully denied. An article in McCall's magazine stated that each year about one million teenagers between the ages of 15 and 19 become pregnant. One survey revealed a 30% increase among teenagers in sexual activity within the last five years. Many other statistics could be quoted to show that we are fast becoming a nation of people who support and practice sexual activity outside of marriage.

What can be done to reverse the head-long plunge into complete moral decadence? Those who run our schools believe the answer lies in teaching our children about the sexual functions of their body from kindergarten through twelfth grade. However, Erma Bombeck offers an alternative option . . . Getting Sex Out of the Schools and Back in the Gutter Where It Belongs. Sometimes the best way to approach a serious topic is with a little bit of humor!

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My son was five years old when his teacher sent home a not informing me he was sexually immature.

I confronted her the next day after school and said, "What is this supposed to mean, Mrs. Kravitz?"

It means we had a little quiz the other day on reproductive organs and he defined every one of them as an Askyourfather. You are sending a child into the world, Mrs. Bombeck, who thinks Masters and Johnson, is a golf tournament and fertilization is something you do in the fall to make the lawns green."

"That's true." I nodded.

"Have you ever discussed sex in your home?" she asked.

"No, but once he caught Barbie and Ken together in a cardboard car in their underwear."

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"Have you ever discussed with him the parts of his body?"

"Only those that showed dirt."

"You have to do better than that. This is a new day, Mrs., Bombeck. We don't hide our heads in the sand anymore. Suburban schools are taking the lead in informing our young people about sex at an early age. For example, I am expecting a baby and I told the class about it."

"You told them you had something in the oven?" I asked incredulously.

"I told them I was pregnant! She said.

I bit my finger "Good Lord, Mrs. Kravitz. I didn't know why my husband gasped every time Lassie cleared the fence until I was twenty-six."

"Then you had better get used to it., your son is about to be informed."

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The suburbs didn't invent sex—it only gave it a wider distribution. No one could have known the ramifications sex education could have had in the community. Little boys wrote dirty sayings on the sidewalks with chalk as they always did, but adults didn't protect. They didn't understand what they meant.

Parents who tried to deal directly with their children by saying, "Look, Brucie, there seems to be some confusion between sexual and asexual reproduction, "only to be interrupted with, "Look, Dad, you should have come to me sooner. What do you need to know?"

Eavesdropping (among young people) dropped off 75 percent but increased 86 percent among adults. And one second grader confronted his parents one night with, "You little devils, you. And you told me I was conceived without sin."

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Things had clearly gotten out of hand and we knew it. So a meeting was called at the school to discuss the future of sex education.

"Frankly," said the librarian, "I'm worried. Do you realize the new National Geographic has been in for three weeks and has not been checked out once by a third grader?"

We gasped. "The youngsters don't wasn't to play Doctor and Nursie anymore," said a distraught father. "My son wants to open up his own office."

"I'm afraid," said Ken Kinsey, "that the impact of sex education goes even deeper. We now have before us the problem of dress code. It seems with the laxity of certain rules and the casualness with which we are regarding the human body, some youngsters are coming to school in various attire. Tonight, we have been asked to consider the

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outcome of displaying—(he swallowed hard)—the navel."

The librarian sucked in her breath. The co-chairman cleared his throat and I grabbed for my son's sex manual to see if it had a double meaning.

"It seems," continued Ken, "that many of our little girls have been wearing jeans that fit around the hips and shirts that hang just below the rib cage and there is a bare area in between that needs some clarification. Anyone have any ideas?"

"Well, I have always felt if the Good Lord had meant for people to go nude He would never have invented the wicker chair," said one mother.

"That is a good point," said Ken. "Anyone else?"

"Have we established what a navel is?" asked a teacher.

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"I think it is safe to assume that most of us are familiar with the navel . . ."

"Wait a minute," said a mother, "there are navels and there are navels. I mean some are `outies` and some are `innies`. I personally find the outies disgusting."

"That's strange," said her husband, "I find them sexy."

"You don't know how strange," said his wife. "I have an `innie` and demand to know where you've seen an 'outie'".

"Please people. Let's get back to the issue here. Should we permit the navel to be displayed in a classroom atmosphere?"

"Today the nave, tomorrow the buttock," grumbled the math teacher.

"It seems to me," said a parent, "that if lax dress codes are allowed to continue, we may be in

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for something that only the National Guard can handle."

"I worry," said a mother who had been sitting quietly, "that it will blow the lid off a whole can of emotions. I mean, how do you expect a six-year-old to stay in the lines when he colors if he is distracted by a bared navel witting at the desk next to his."

"That's a good point, Ethel," said Ken.

"I see nothing wrong with navels," said a militant in the rear. "Why are all of you so hung up over something as normal as a navel?"

"Navels are not on trial here," interrupted Ken. "It's simply we must draw the line somewhere with the relaxing of morals among our young people.

"So, if you're ashamed of your navel," persisted the militant, "I'll put a Band-Aid over it."

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"What does the U.S. government say about navels?"Asked a businessman.

"To my knowledge, there is no department at the moment that is conducting any sort of findings on the subject," said Ken. "If we could just get back to the subject . . ."

"If you ask me," said a concerned mother, "I think by our condoning navels in a public-school building, we are lowering the age of puberty. Next thing you know, we will permit them to have acne before they are tem and lower their voices at nine. I say they are growing up too fast. Let's save the navels for later when they can handle them and enjoy them like adults."

There was a round of applause and a few in the back stood up and said, "Here, here."

"Should we put it to a vote?" asked Ken. "Okay, all of you in favor of issuing a dress code in

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which navels must be covered, signify by saying , 'Aye" (a roar). Opposed? (One, "you bet your sweet umbilical cord!')

"Now, the next thing on the agenda," said Ken nervously, "is Miss Barker who teaches third-graders human sexuality, would like to have a lab . . ."

I slipped out the back door. I wanted time to consider the ramifications, the objectives, the impact of bringing such a program within my child's learning processes. Also, to have my six-year-old explain to me what human sexuality is.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Erma Bombeck
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